Representations of People with Disabilities: A Multimodal Critical Discourse Analysis of Selected Instagram Posts from Disability Rights Advocacy Centre (DRAC)

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Abstract
The purpose of this study is to critically examine how social media users construct, negotiate and represent disability on Nigerian Instagram posts. Despite global advancements in disability rights advocacy, people with disabilities (henceforth PWDs) in Nigeria continue to face stigma, discrimination, and exclusion rooted in cultural beliefs and systemic neglect. Using a Multimodal Critical Discourse Analysis (MCDA) approach, the study investigates the interplay between linguistic and visual elements in selected graphics on Nigerian Instagram posts to uncover the ideological, social and political meanings embedded in these representations. Through an analysis of written texts, images, captions, hashtags, and other semiotic resources, the study reveals how these are used to shape societal attitudes, narratives and perceptions towards people with disability. The study also reveals certain power dynamics such as marginalisation versus agency/visibility, and paternalism versus empowerment showing how the Instagram users challenge societal judgmental narratives in order to influence inclusion and social justice of PWDs.
Key words: Stigmatization, stereotyping, people with disabilities, labels of primary potency, Multimodality, critical discourse.

Introduction
Disability constitutes a significant demographic reality and an important socio-political concern in Nigeria, with an estimated 23 million people living with various forms of disabilities (Global Disability Fund 1). The World Health Organization defines disability as a condition involving impairment or abnormality in psychological, physiological, or anatomical structure or function that may restrict an individual's ability to perform activities within the range considered normal for human beings. The organisation further explains that a handicap refers to the disadvantage that results from such impairments, particularly when they limit an individual's ability to perform socially expected roles within specific cultural contexts (213). From this perspective, disability does not imply inadequacy or incapability; rather, it represents a form of impairment that constitutes a universal human condition which anyone may experience at different stages of life.
Disabilities take diverse forms, including mobility, visual, auditory, cognitive, neurological, and mental health impairments. These include conditions such as cerebral palsy, muscular dystrophy, traumatic brain injury, intellectual disabilities, autism spectrum disorder, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, depression, anxiety disorders,

schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, and visual or hearing impairments. Despite the enactment of the Discrimination Against Persons with Disabilities (Prohibition) Act 2018 in Nigeria, persons with disabilities continue to face widespread discrimination and marginalisation in education, employment, healthcare, and public life.

In Nigeria, disability is often interpreted on the basis of culture and superstition. As Osita Ogbu observes, people with disabilities are frequently perceived as inferior, with their conditions attributed to curses, witchcraft, or divine punishment, leading to stigma and social isolation for both individuals and their families (23). Similarly, Colin Barnes and Mike Mercer argue that societal attitudes towards disability are deeply shaped by cultural and historical contexts that perpetuate negative stereotypes and discrimination. Such beliefs portray persons with disabilities (PWDs) as dependent, incapable, or burdensome, often resulting in social exclusion, restricted educational and employment opportunities, and inadequate access to healthcare services (527). Consequently, many PWDs experience marginalisation, loss of dignity, and limited participation in social and economic life (Ogbu 30).

In response to these persistent challenges, digital technologies and social media platforms have increasingly become important spaces for advocacy and representation. Among these platforms, Instagram offers significant multimodal affordances that enable users to combine images, captions, hashtags, and emojis in the communication of social issues. According to Gunther Kress and Theo van Leeuwen, the integration of multiple semiotic resources in digital environments creates discursive spaces in which meanings can be constructed, negotiated, and reinterpreted (45). In Nigeria, where smartphone use and digital literacy are steadily increasing, Instagram has become an important platform for activism, public engagement, and advocacy (Page et al 7). Civil society organisations, activists, and advocacy groups increasingly use the platform to tell the stories of persons with disabilities, challenge negative perceptions, and mobilise support for inclusive policies.

As Precious Sango and Roy Deveau observe, Nigeria's poorly funded social welfare system means that most forms of support for individuals with disabilities are provided by families, communities, or religious institutions (475). Globally, the situation remains similarly challenging. For instance, Elekanachi et al. estimate that approximately 240 million children live with disabilities worldwide, with the majority residing in low- and middle-income countries where access to healthcare and social services is limited (1). The World Report on Disability further estimates the prevalence of moderate and severe disabilities in Africa at 3.1% and 15.3% respectively, with communicable and infectious diseases identified as major contributing factors (2).

Against this background, advocacy organisations play an essential role in challenging discriminatory narratives and promoting inclusive representation. One of such organisations is the Disability Rights Advocacy Center (DRAC), a Nigerian non-profit organisation founded by Irene Ojuigo Patrick-Ogbogu in 2011 in Abuja. DRAC focuses on protecting the rights of persons with disabilities and promoting their social inclusion through advocacy, policy engagement, capacity building, and community-based initiatives. The organisation also addresses issues affecting women and girls with disabilities, including sexual and gender-based violence, through programmes such as the "Break the Cycle" project. Central to its mission is the promotion of inclusive narratives

and the transformation of social attitudes, recognising language and representation as key drivers of inclusion. It is selected amongst other advocacy oragnisations because the multimodal nature of its data meet the goals of our study.

This study therefore examines the constructions and representations of disability on the Instagram platform of DRAC in Nigeria. It focuses on selected posts originating from Nigeria and analyses how linguistic and visual resources interact in the representation of disability. The study integrates the metafunctions framework of M. A. K. Halliday within Systemic Functional Linguistics with the visual grammar developed by Gunther Kress and Theo van Leeuwen. The combination of these frameworks is particularly suitable for Multimodal Critical Discourse Analysis because it enables the examination of how linguistic and visual elements jointly construct meanings about disability. More importantly, the approach moves beyond semiotic description to interrogate how multimodal choices reflect social power relations, ideological positions, and patterns of inclusion or marginalisation.

Using purposive sampling, five posts from a single Instagram account are analysed. The aim of the study is to examine the interplay of textual, visual, and other semiotic resources in advocating the rights and inclusion of persons with disabilities. Specifically, the study examines how DRAC's narratives construct and represent persons with disabilities on Instagram; analyses the power dynamics and societal ideologies embedded in these narratives; and explores how multimodal resources are used to challenge stereotypes, condemn stigmatisation, and promote disability inclusion.

Review of scholarship

Several studies have been done on stigma and stereotypes of PWDs. For instance, Catherine Toutin opines that students (with disability) have internalized the social construction and societal views of disability and feel that they are weak for requesting or using accommodations (499). Toutin's research focuses on postsecondary students living with disability and how better strategies can be deployed in ensuring that they are maximally cared for in order to ensure inclusiveness in the society. Also, Lavonne Kopca affirms that by acknowledging and addressing stigma and discrimination, we can work towards creating a more inclusive society and higher education institutions that value diversity and promote equal opportunities for all (105). Kopca's study applies critical discourse analysis to examine how college students with disabilities are perceived as an overlooked minority population. In addition, Martin Wilbur's Ph.D dissertation underscores a discourse analysis of representations of disabled characters in scripted television programmes. He opines that "realistic representations of disability can help alleviate the stigma attached to the 'other' by serving to educate the typical population" (167). Jan Grue asserts that "the identity markers of class, gender, race, and ethnicity are being supplemented by that *disability*" (532). Grue's view challenges the stereotypical perception of PWDs, asserting that beyond the veil of any form of disability, humans with career and social life should be regarded and addressed with their capabilities regardless of their physical condition. Kayode Niyi Afolayan and Olushola Ayodeji Akanmode examine how disability is symbolically represented in the novels *Age of Iron* and *Disgrace* by J. M. Coetzee. Using a qualitative literary method, the authors conduct a close textual analysis of the novels, drawing on insights from Disability Studies to interpret disability

as a cultural and narrative representation rather than merely a medical condition. The study finds that "disability functions as a metaphor for the social and moral crises of post-apartheid South Africa, reflecting broader experiences of violence, instability, and collective trauma" (51). It also highlights how bodily weakness and illness reveal the vulnerability of human existence while challenging ideas of power and control. Thus, despite suffering and marginalization, the novels present disability through motifs of endurance, survival, and ethical reflection that encourage empathy toward vulnerable individuals.

Disability transcends physical impairment. It could also be a psychological trauma any individual may face when such individual encounters negative experiences. The scholars reviewed here examined disability from several perspectives, applying different theories. But the multimodal study of disability and how it challenges stereotypes and stigma on Instagram is missing as at the time of this study. This study therefore aims to address this gap in scholarship. By critically analyzing the interplay of text, visuals and other semiotic resources, it will provide insights into how media shape perceptions of the public about people living with disabilities, re-orient the beliefs of the public, influence primitive social negative responses, and suggest humane language for the inclusion of PWDs. The findings of this study will be useful to the general public, policymakers, advocates, and media practitioners who seek more effective means of raising awareness, advocating and seeking justice and equal opportunities for all.

Conceptual Framework

This study integrates M. A. K. Halliday's three metafunctions of language – ideational, interpersonal, and textual with the visual grammar proposed by Gunther Kress and Theo van Leeuwen, namely representational, interactional, and compositional meanings, to analyse advocacy posts produced by the Disability Rights Advocacy Center (DRAC) on Instagram. Halliday's metafunctions explain how language functions to represent experience (ideational), enact social relationships (interpersonal), and organize messages into coherent discourse (textual). Complementing this linguistic perspective, Kress and van Leeuwen's visual grammar demonstrates how images communicate meaning through visual structures, participant representation, and viewer interaction. By combining these frameworks, the study examines how linguistic and visual semiotic resources work together in Instagram advocacy posts to construct meaning, shape audience engagement, and reveal power relations and ideological positions surrounding disability.

Systemic Functional Linguistics (SFL)

SFL originally developed by Michael Alexander Kirkwood Halliday in the 1960's in the UK was influenced by European functionalism as conceived by his teacher, J.R. Firth. His aim is to explain how language makes meaning and how language is organized to fulfil a range of social functions. It hinges on the premise that language is a network of interrelated systems and this set of system offers the speaker/writer unlimited choices for meaning-making. So, the speaker picks from this 'unlimited choices' to express himself. The idea of 'systemic' in SFL examines language as a potential for choices, with those alternatives functioning in a particular context. A systemic approach allows focusing on

vital language choices (active versus passive) without analysing the underlying structure. The basic notion is that meaning involves selection from the structure.

Thus, it is crucial to consider what a language does (function) than what it is (form or structure). In its view, language serves a variety of purposes. Grammar is organized in terms of units and function, such as subject and actor. Texts represent a whole as serving distinct social functions by conveying information to establish or maintain social relations; a speech function (like speech act theory) applies to each utterance, such as providing information (statement), demanding information (question), demanding action (order), and so on. As Halliday and Mattheissen note, a systemic functional view of language places communication methods in social contexts and considers how language serves in the construction of meaning (248). SFL is therefore significant to this study because it provides the possibility for the analysis of texts in contexts.

The summary of the framework of SFL is ideational - here, we have the concept of Transitivity, Participants-human, non-human (nominal and roles e.g. 'actor', 'goal', 'beneficiary', etc; Process-material, mental, behavioural, existential, verbal and relational (verbs); Circumstance of place, time, manner and cause (adverbials) Voice: active and passive; Interpersonal-Mood (statements, questions, demands) Modality –modal verbs. Textual- Cohesive devices (conjunctions and connectors); Clause combining strategies, Thematic organization (theme and rheme). Below is an improvised table summarising the framework of Halliday's Systemic Functional Linguistics.

Metafunctions	Types	Realisations in Texts
Ideational	Transitivity Participants (human and non-human) Process (verbs) Circumstance (adverbials) Voice	Nominal and roles, e.g., actor, goal, beneficiary. Material, mental, behavioural, existential, verbal, and relational. Place, manner, time, and cause Active and passive
Interpersonal	Mood Modality (modal verbs and adjuncts)	Statements, questions, demands, and so on. Certainty, possibility, necessity, obligation, permission, persuasion, and so on.
Textual	Cohesive devices Clause combining strategies Thematic organization	Conjunctions and connectors Theme and rheme

Fig 1: An improvised Table showing Halliday's metafunctions

Visual Grammar

Visual grammar analytical framework is a component of social approach to examine how certain ideologies are embedded in multimodal semiotic resources. Multimodality mainly focuses on the study of the interrelationships between modes (a channel that expresses a message; whether visual or auditory, words or images) and has a potential meaning. In discourse, the study of how the different modes interact in the meaning-making process, particularly how different modes uncover social relationships, power dynamics and ideologies is referred to as multimodal critical discourse analysis (MCDA).

According to Kress and van Leeuwen, "the visual is always in constant interaction with one or more of the other modes and is always affected by those interactions" (xiv). The semiotic potential of any sign is defined by the semiotic resources available to a specific individual in a specific social context (Kress and van Leeuwen 9). The social semiotic approach to studying semiotic resources employs Halliday's Systemic Functional Linguistic template as an analytical tool to show how modes such as images account for the ideational, interpersonal and textual functions of signs (modes). Just as grammars of language describe how words combine in clauses, sentences and texts, so the grammar of the visual describes how depicted elements-people, places and things combine in visual 'statements' of greater or lesser complexity and extension (1).

In VG, Kress and Van Leeuwen rename Halliday's metafunctions thus: Ideational –representational; Interpersonal – interactive, and Textual – compositional. But unlike the linguistic mode where one would describe the grammar of English, Spanish, etc., VG describes the social semiotic resource of a particular group (*Reading* 4). The analytical tools in VG are represented thus:

Representational	
Participant:	actor, goal, senser, phenomenon, etc., and vector relationships
Process	– action, mental state or behaviour
Circumstance	– where, when, accompaniment
Interactive	– direction of gaze, involvement, power relations, social distance.
Compositional	– information value, salience and framing.

Below is an improvised diagram summarizing the framework of Kress and van Leeuwen's Visual Grammar.

Metafunction	Types	Realization in Image
Representational	Participants: (Narrative and conceptual) Vector relationship/process Circumstance	Actor, goal, senser, phenomenon (Action and reaction), classification, definition, and analysis Lines, shapes, etc.,/Action, mental state or behaviour Where, when, accompaniment
Interactive	Gaze/contact Social distance Perspective (attitude) Modality	'offer', 'demand'/direct and indirect Involvement, power relations Close-up, medium and long shot Horizontal and vertical High, and low modality
Compositional	Information value Framing Salience	Top/bottom, left/right, and centre/margin Separation, Segregation, Overlap, and so on Foreground/Background, size, and colour.

Fig 2: An improvised table showing Kress and Van Leeuwen's metafunctions

Multimodality focuses on people's process of meaning-making, a process in which people make choices from a network of alternatives: selecting one modal resource (meaning potential) over another (Halliday 22). Halliday suggests that every sign simultaneously tells us something about 'the world' (ideational meaning), positions us in relation to someone or something (interpersonal meaning) and produces a structured text (textual meaning) (23). Kress and Van Leeuwen define multimodal "as that which integrates more than one semiotic mode in communicative functions" (183).

Materials and Methods

The data for this study are sourced from the official Instagram page of Disability Rights Advocacy Centre (DRAC), a non-governmental organization fighting for the rights and inclusion of PWDs in the society. The study adopts a qualitative descriptive design to analyse texts in context. Out of the many datasets that were collected, the purposive random sampling method was used to select five datasets because they meet the aim and objectives of this study. The datasets were analysed by integrating Halliday's meta-function with Kress and Van Leeuwen's visual grammar.

Data Presentation and Analysis

This section presents the graphics and the multimodal analysis.

Plate 1

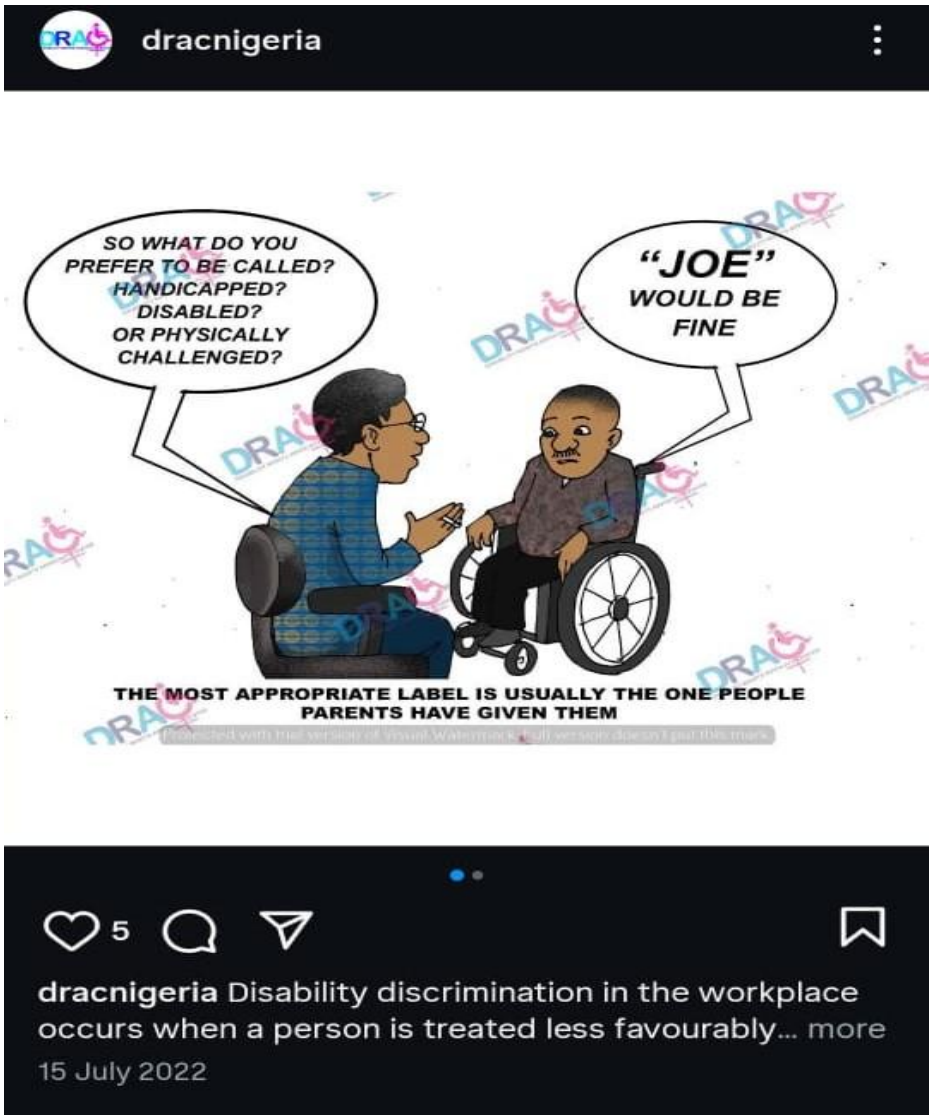

Figure 1: Source- DRAC
Posted 15/07/2022; Extracted; 21/07/2025

First, we consider the representational/ideational level of analysis. The composite text has the image of two men who are the main participants. On the left is a man (a questioner) who is possibly a care giver, health worker or an interviewer; and on the right is another man in a wheelchair named "Joe". And the written texts read: The Questioner: "SO WHAT DO YOU PREFER TO BE CALLED? HANDICAPPED? DISABLED? OR PHYSICALLY CHALLENGED?" The Responder: "JOE" WOULD BE FINE". What is expressed in the exchange between both men is the representation of the experiences of

people living with disabilities in the society. The interviewer is the actor who initiates the conversation around identity labels, while "Joe" is the goal who tries to assert his preference irrespective of what the society has decided to label him. Besides, Joe is human who is not reduced to his condition, but rather, represented as an individual first, with a name, voice, and agency, using the mental process "prefer" and the non-finite "to be called" to suggest desire/choice. The visuals are narrative processes as the gesture and gaze of both participants create vectors that suggest disapproval and disdain from the part of Joe as he expresses himself, battling for his own identity. Joe is active with his speech, challenging the passive representation of disability. Although the question represents people living with disability as vulnerable and incomplete humans, his response leaves him with a choice. The exchange reflects the struggle of identity, and its negotiation that is peculiar to people living with disability in everyday contexts. The setting of the background is plain, undefined and neutral. This gives viewers the clue that the issue of labelling and stigmatization of people living with disability transcends location, and occurs in everyday context.

At the Interpersonal/Interactive level, the interrogative mood "SO WHAT DO YOU PREFER TO BE CALLED? HANDICAPPED? DISABLED? OR PHYSICALLY CHALLENGED?" indicates power dynamics, reflecting societal perceptions of people living with disability. The question uses neutral modality to reveal stereotypes and stigmatization, affirming unequal status between the questioner and the responder. This is challenged by the subtle reply of Joe through the declarative, "Joe would be fine", affirming the identity and agency of the individual. Despite its subtleness, Joe's response expresses high modality, exhibiting assertiveness, confidence and self-determination. More so, the participants wear different colours (blue for the questioner, and brown for Joe) to differentiate them. The blue colour signifies calmness and neutrality, yet contrasts the tone of the questioner, while the brown colour and neutral tones worn by Joe is symbolic of realism and confidence, asserting first, personhood before any challenge. It is further reinforced by a transactional interaction as both participants directly gaze at each other, suggesting equality and mutual recognition. The logo of the organization "DRAC" printed in bright pink and blue visualizes a positive tone, reminding the viewers who the sayer is. In all, the realistic presentation of human skin, clothing and wheelchair expresses high modality, acknowledging disability as sometimes naturalistic or accidental, but most importantly, a normal phase of human lives. Therefore, people should be respected and seen as humans first before any impairment. The lack of gaze towards the viewers place them as observers who should watch and contemplate their actions and inactions towards people living with disability. The image is shot at a medium range which allows the viewers to see the participants from the waist level to their faces, upper bodies, including the wheelchair. Also, in terms of social distance, the frontal angle and eye-level shot of the participants imply equality between them. This helps to promote empathy as the participants are humanized irrespective of the challenge one of them has. No one is subsumed but rather, they are placed side by side to indicate equality. This suggests the ideology of inclusion and humanity.

At the textual/compositional level, the written text and every other multimodal resources cohere to realise the message of the composite text. The first participant's question sets the theme of labels imposed on people living with disability, not by the

impairment they suffer from, but by the society, while the rheme is the new information given by Joe. Joe's response assertively kicks against such labels, reaffirming personhood first. In terms of information value, the questioner's speech is on the left and it represents the societal traditional belief and assumption that people with disability are either cursed or evil and as such, should not be equated with normal humans in the society, suggesting the ideology of "us" versus "them". Joe's speech is on the right and it represents a "shift" in ideology and perception. His position is deliberate, suggestive of the "right" thing to do and say. Thus, it implies dignity and self-esteem. In terms of salience, the way the images are structured, using dialogues, draws the attention of the viewers, leading to the caption beneath. The visual images are framed from left to right alongside their speeches in interactional space. This symbolizes communication which is vital to people living with disability in contrast to mere isolation.

The captions below "THE MOST APPROPRAITE LABEL IS USUALLY THE ONE PEOPLE [sic] PARENTS HAVE GIVEN THEM", and "DISABILITY DISCRIMINATION IN THE WORKPLACE OCCURS WHEN A PERSON IS TREATED LESS FAVOURABLY" both challenge stereotypes, stigmatization and advocate the inclusion of people living with disability in all spheres of life. The first caption "THE MOST APPROPRIATE LABEL IS USUALLY THE ONE PEOPLE [sic] PARENTS HAVE GIVEN THEM" condemns the stereotypes of considering impairment as an alternate label for individuals living with disability. It counters the reduction of people with disabilities to medical or functional labels like "the disabled", "wheelchair bound", "physically, visually or hearing impaired", and so on. These impersonal or stigmatised labels affect the individuals, concealing their capabilities and capacities as full-fledged humans who have the acumen to contribute towards the growth and development of the society in which they live in. The above caption emphasises that every individual is first, a human being with a life and a name, and an identity beyond their disability. Thus, names given by parents should be used to identify persons instead of words like "disabled", "impaired", "disadvantaged", and the likes. The second statement "DISABILITY DISCRIMINATION IN THE WORKPLACE OCCURS WHEN A PERSON IS TREATED LESS FAVOURABLY" identifies the injustice that is often melted to people living with disability, positioning society as the problem, rather than the challenge – disability. The society always perceive PWDs as unemployable and incapable, projecting their insecurities on innocent people. Also, it frames this exclusion and injustice as unfair and unnatural, emphasizing that everyone has fundamental human rights irrespective of the challenge. So, societal norms of ableism should not be normalized, but rather, equal opportunity should be given to everyone. Everyone should be seen and identified the way they want to be, and not what the society has labeled them to be.

Plate 2

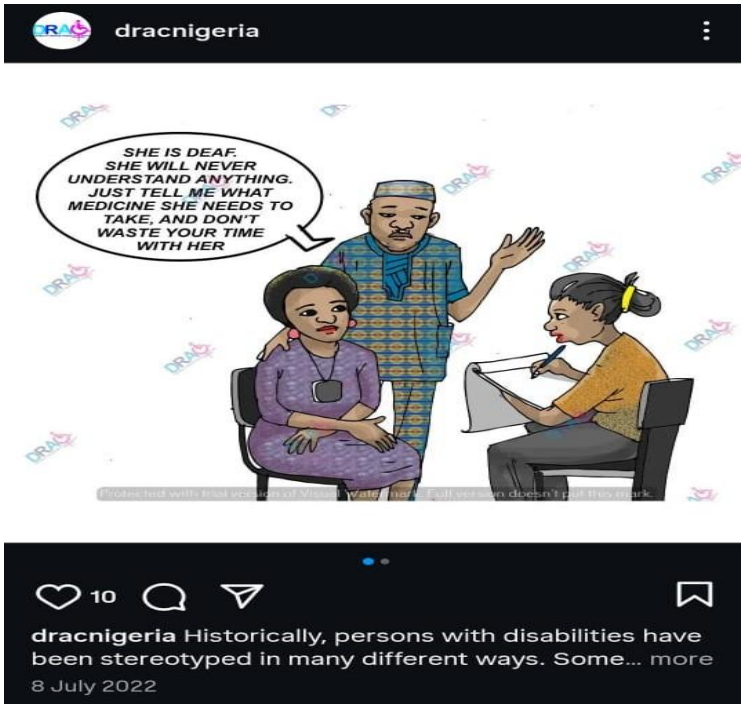

Figure 2: Source- DRAC
Posted; 08/07/2022; Extracted; 21/07/2025

There are three participants in plate two above- a woman who is both the actor and goal of discriminatory assumptions, a man speaking is the senser or sayer who expresses the societal position, and a health professional who is the recipient/behaver, a representative of a potential advocate in a neutral role. Towards the left of the image is the man's speech: "SHE IS DEAF. SHE WILL NEVER UNDERSTAND ANYTHING. JUST TELL ME WHAT MEDICINE SHE NEEDS TO TAKE AND DON'T WASTE YOUR TIME WITH HER". The material process "...TELL ME WHAT MEDICINE SHE NEEDS..." assumes the woman to be incapable of expressing herself, and making a decision that concerns her health. So, she is excluded from important issues that concerns her life. The composite text has a narrative structure where the image has both actional and reactional process. The man's gesture positions him as someone in authority, acting as the omniscient in the image. The woman's posture is passive with the way she sits, her hands on her laps and her sore eyes, so innocent. The health practitioner writes, yet gives a direct gaze at the woman, signifying attention. The man's stance creates a vector relationship, as his body posture dominates, commands power. The woman's indirect gaze reflects fear and social marginalisation, while the man dominates the interaction in the circumstance of a medical consultation or hospital meeting.

At the interpersonal/interactive level, the declarative mood "...SHE WILL NEVER UNDERSTAND..." expresses high modality of certainty, reinforcing stereotype and stigmatisation that PWDs are not capable, intelligent or worthy of being addressed directly/given attention to. This is explained by the woman's silence and facial expression.

It reveals the fact that although she is deaf, she is sensitive to the unfair treatment she is being given. She looks sad, suppressed and disempowered. The gesture (writing, yet making eye contact) of the health practitioner is a subtle challenge of the poor perception of the man, indirectly shunning negative language on PDWs. The background colours help project the images at the foreground. The colours of the images are realistic, presenting them as true humans who are engaging in a serious issue. Their clothing are formal, reflective of the authenticity of an institutionalized setting where professional services are carried out.

At the textual/compositional level, the text is placed at the top-left space of the composite text with a pointer to whom the speech is ascribed, while the woman is placed at the centre to capture viewers' attention, signifying the affected. Unfortunately, the man's posture almost dominates her. The health professional is placed at the right position, suggesting an advocate who is keen on the "right" language to use for PWDs in the society. The woman living with disability is overpowered and looks too burdened to interfere in whatever way she can. This power imbalance creates a mental social marginalization that has been a bane in the society. All the participants are framed together, suggestive of the systemic exclusion of PWDs. In terms of social distance, the image is shot at a medium range which suggests personal involvement, capturing viewers' attention to reflect their own biases towards PWDs in the society. The frontal view of the images creates in the viewers' mind the need to be empathetic (in terms of language use), presenting them as witnesses of societal stereotypes, stigmatization and exclusion of PWDs in the society.

The caption beneath reads: "HISTORICALLY, PERSONS WITH DISABILITY HAVE BEEN STEREOTYPED IN MANY WAYS". The above caption underscores the systemic injustice that is being done to PWDs in different spheres of life. This is reinforced by the speaker's attempt to bypass the woman. Excluding her from such important decision presents her as invalid, incapacitated and unimportant simply because of an impairment. Beyond the impairment, she is a beautiful woman with a name, a career (possibly), a mother (possibly), a sister, an aunt, a niece, and so on. Disregarding these exceptionalities to concentrate on a single impairment is a problem to be concerned about, not necessarily the impairment itself. Stereotyping harms the image and perception of people, thus representation matters. This is a means of challenging the poor representation of PWDs, advocating their rights and inclusion in the society. This is seen in the health practitioner who is listening, bearing the responsibility of a professional. All we need do is "listen" and be respectful with the way we communicate with PDWs around us. Both written and visual elements invite the general public to critically reflect on their attitudes and make a positive adjustment for a social change.

Plate 3

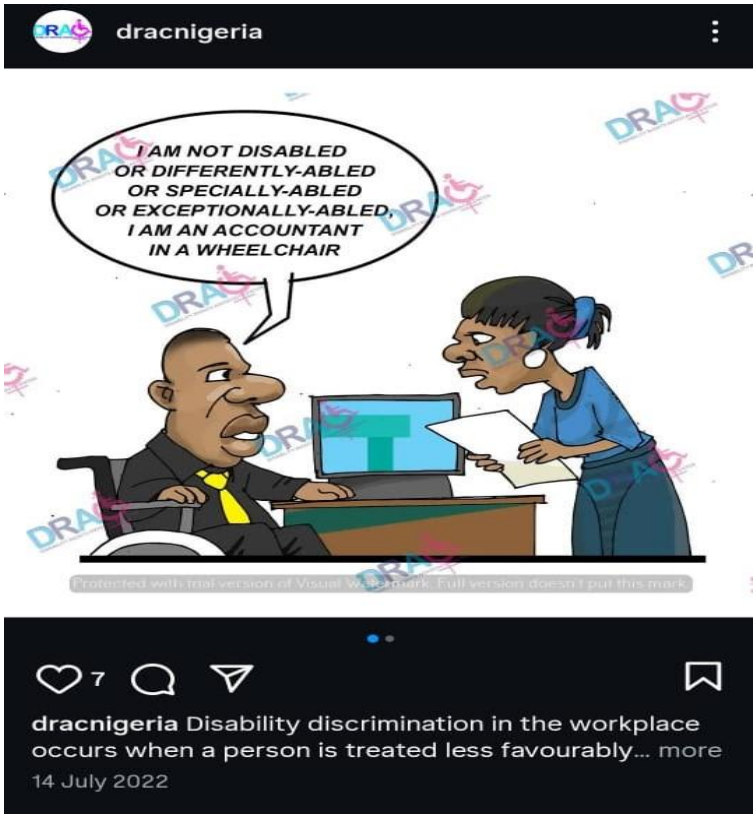

Figure 3: Source- DRAC
Posted; 14/07/2022; Extracted; 21/07/2025

At the textual/representational level, the composite text has two participants-a man in a wheelchair who is the actor/sayer and carrier of the identity "disabled", and a lady, possibly a colleague who is the receiver of the message and a symbolic representation of the society with unconscious bias. The speech of the man reads: "I AM NOT DISABLED OR DIFFERENTLY-ABLED OR SPECIALLY-ABLED OR EXCEPTIONALLY-ABLED. I AM AN ACCOUNTANT IN A WHEELCHAIR". This is a response to an implicit comment obviously made by the lady. The verbal process in the above speech resists imposed labels and identities that use euphemism. The irony involved in these euphemisms is that it gives prior knowledge of a problem, yet trying to conceal it. He wants to be addressed just as every other person in the office. He is assertive about what he wants. He does not want to be misrepresented at all. He tries to avoid what Gordon Allport calls "labels of primary potency that prevents alternative classification" (qtd. in Linda Thomas et al 100). He is human, and an accountant, a professional who does his job just like every other person. He thus corrects the notion of substituting his identity for his impairment, deconstructing deficit framing by echoing "I AM AN ACCOUNTANT IN A WHEELCHAIR". The narrative structure of the images presents the actor in a wheelchair, while the lady is leaning

forward, holding papers. The man is centrally positioned and active despite the assumed stereotypical belief about his physical appearance. And the context is an office.

At the interpersonal/interactive meta-function, the declarative mood employs definitive language "I AM NOT… I AM…" to assert his confidence, and control, challenging social labelling that stigmatizes, expressing high modality of certainty and assertion. He is fully aware of who he is. So, he should not be patronized through bias labels. Although the tone is non-confrontational, it is firm and clear, aiming to educate and reclaim. The office props-realistic skin tones, and corporate attire give credibility to the authenticity of the image, presenting them as real people in real world. The man has a direct contact with the lady, emphasising his role as the boss with an intent to correct as his social presence is assertive. The lady's direct gaze also shows that she is paying attention to what the man is saying, but her body language (leaning forward, holding documents) depicts her as the subordinate who is listening/ taking corrections from her boss. Both images present an "offer" gaze to the viewers, positioning them to observe and contemplate.

At the textual/compositional level, the written texts illustrate the images. The written text is structured in a contrastive way that suggests "not this", but "this", thus using parallelism to discard negative labels, and at the same time asserting positive identity. In terms of framing, the image of the man in a wheelchair is positioned at the left side of the composite text, while that of the lady is placed at the right side. At the top is the speech bubble which asserts the ideological stance of self- assertiveness and inclusion, while at the bottom are the desk, wheelchair and papers, suggesting the reality of work. All the elements (both animate and inanimate) are framed within a single text to convey the ideologies of integration, inclusion and shared communication. In terms of salience, the man's dark suite and yellow tie creates a sharp contrast with the lady's light blue top and grey skirt. The essence is to focalise the man, making him the dominant factor in the text. It is a break from the common ideology of marginalisation. This time, it is a shift in pattern, reinforcing positive self-representation, dignity, and empowerment.
Additionally, the misrepresentation of PWDs is challenged by the caption below which reads: "Disability discrimination in the workplace occurs when a person is treated less favourably". The above statement is factual as it names injustice, reframes disability not as a condition but a social problem, asserting equality as a right and not favour. It challenges the unfair treatment given to PWDs. The Nigerian society has a way of euphemistically excluding PWDs in workplaces. The bias is a systemic problem which this study also aims to address. Irrespective of the euphemisms used for labels, it has a stereotypical undertone and stigma attached to it. Language has been used for this labelling, therefore, language is also instrumental to the inclusion of PWDs in our society.

Plate 4

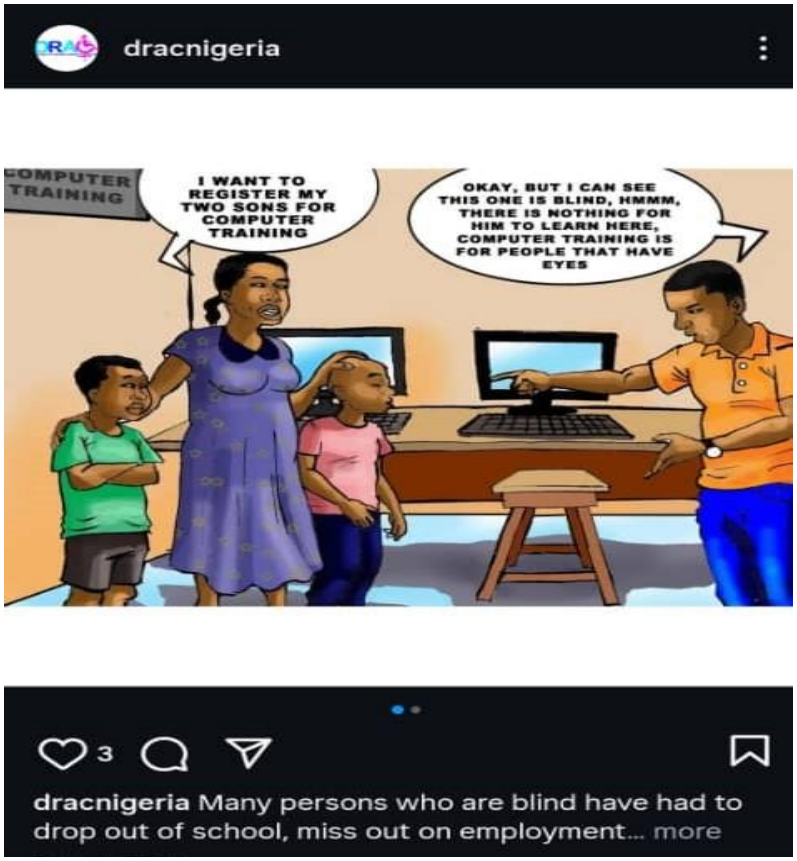

Figure 4: Source – DRAC
Posted; 29/07/2022; Extracted; 21/07/2025

There are four participants in plate four-- a woman with her two children at the left, and a man (perceived as the computer trainer) at the right of the composite text. Their conversations are enclosed in speech bubbles.

WOMAN: "I WANT TO REGISTER MY TWO SONS FOR COMPUTER TRAINING". TRAINER: "OKAY, BUT I CAN SEE THIS ONE IS BLIND, HMMM, THERE IS NOTHING FOR HIM TO LEARN HERE, COMPUTER TRAINING IS FOR THOSE THAT HAVE EYES". This is a representation of the reality of PWDs in the society as their identity is reduced to their impairments. He addresses the boy as "this one", stereotyping and stigmatizing him because of his impairment. The material process "to register" is used by the woman to express an intention that ensures inclusiveness, but it is met with an unwelcomed pointing of finger which creates a vector, spotting the young man with the impairment. The trainer's action and inaction blames the young boy, projecting him as the reason for his stereotypical attitude. He therefore equates the young boy's blindness with incapacity. Hence his statement: "...computer training is for those that have eyes".

At the interpersonal/interactive level, the interactants (the woman and the trainer) face each other, leaving the viewers to listen, observe and judge. The mother makes a polite request "I want to register...". She is calm and cooperative, trying to do what is right for her children. Meanwhile, the trainer's response is conservative and judgmental. He asserts "there is nothing for him here...". He is loud and assertive in his rejection. This

high modality expresses absolute stigma and stereotypes which are problems to society. Thus, the boy is positioned as a passive recipient of this stigmatization.

At the textual/compositional level, the images, background colours, foregrounding and written texts cohere. The trainer's speech is foregrounded as it dominates visually and verbally. The dialogues are arranged from left to right with proper spacing which represents movement from the point of inclusion to the point of exclusion. The victim (representing PWDs) is framed together with his family, separated by the trainer's speech. The trainer's extended arm covers the centre of the composite text, creating mental salience.

Plate 5

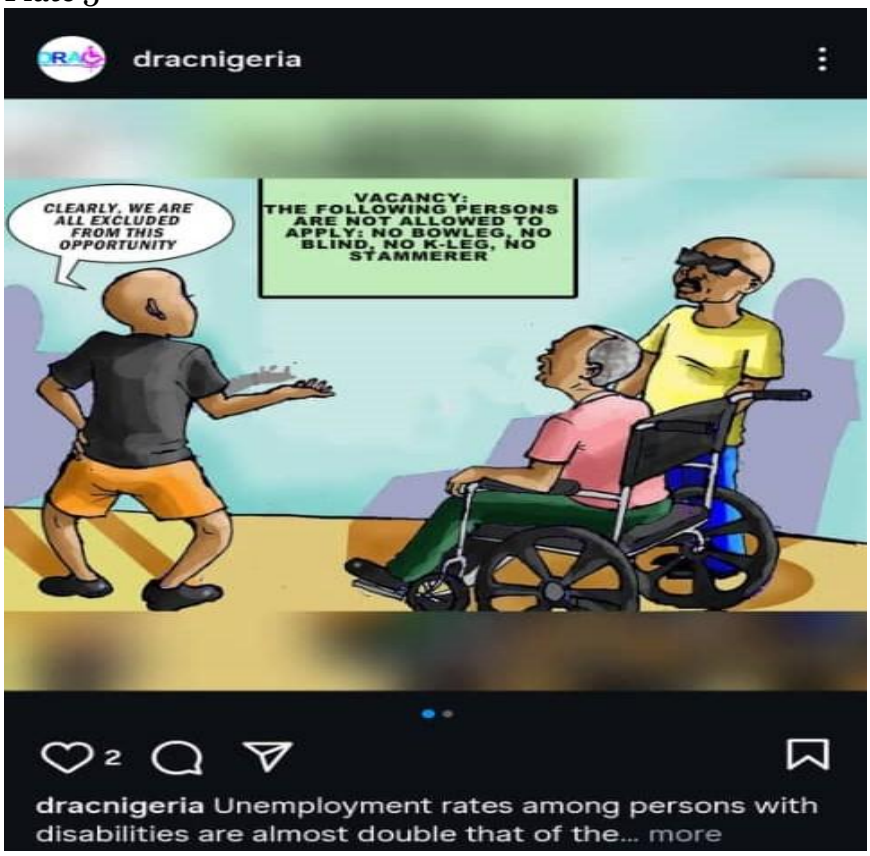

Figure 5: Source – DRAC
Posted; 05/08/2022; Extracted; 21/07/2025

At the ideational/representational level, we have three participants: one on the left and two on the right. They are men who are challenged in one way or the other. There is a vacancy sign which reads "VACANCY, THE FOLLOWING PERSONS ARE NOT ALLOWED TO APPLY: NO BOWLEG, NO BLIND, NO K-LEG, NO STAMMERER". There is a response from the man on the left has a speech bubble ascribed to him. It reads: "CLEARLY, WE ARE ALL EXCLUDED FROM THIS OPPORTUNITY". What is represented here is the ugly stereotyping and stigmatization of PWDs. As we can see, the identity of individuals are replaced with negative labels such as "bowleg", "blind", "k-leg",

"stammerer", neglecting the personhood of the individuals. These words frame PWDs as deficient individuals, and as such, marginalized and not welcomed. The sentence used the relative verbal process "are not allowed" to authoritatively prohibit people in such categories from making appearance at all talk less of applying for positions. So, proving their abilities is not even thought of because opportunity is not given in the first place. The man (with bowlegs) gestures, as he points is finger towards the sign which has the inscription that prohibits PWDs from applying for the job opportunity. His outstretched arm creates a vector, drawing viewers' attention to the sign. More so, both participants are facing one another, towards the direction of the sign post.

At the interpersonal/interactive level, the participants are engaged in a serious conversation, not directly gazing at the viewers, therefore leaving them to pause and contemplate on the issue of stereotype and stigmatization of PWDs in the society. The act of stereotype and stigmatisation are depicted by the stigmatizing labels which dehumanize. They are reinforced by the imperatives "are not allowed to apply", positioning employers as all-powerful, while PWDs are represented as powerless. The mood of the sentence is declarative, presenting exclusion as a statement of fact, leaving no room for negotiation. So, the recipients are cowered into their shells irrespective of what they can offer because of societal negative labels. The speech bubble "CLEARLY, WE ARE ALL EXCLUDED FROM THIS OPPORTUNITY" is also declarative, but functions as a comment reinforcing the inevitability of exclusion. This reflects the power imbalance between people perceived as "normal human beings" in the society, and those perceived as "abnormal" because of their challenges. Both statements express high modality, conveying absolute certainty and authority. This reflects structural stereotypes and stigmatization, legitimizing discrimination as a natural thing.

At the textual/compositional level, the written elements cohere with the images to realise the theme of the composite text. The plain colours of the background help to project the human images, the speech bubble and the vacancy notice on the foreground. The vacancy notice is placed at the top, signifying the ideal authority of the institution. It is visually framed in a way that separates it from the participants, reinforcing stigmatization, while the participants are placed at the bottom left and right positions, representing the reality/lived experiences of PWDs who are the direct recipients of stereotypes and stigmatization in the society. This hierarchical positioning is deliberate, placing societal laws above PWDs. Also, the bright green colour of the vacancy notice dominates, making it the most salient element in the composite text. This draws the viewers' gaze to the injustice that is being, melted on a group of people simply because they have one or two challenges. The theme of the sentence (on the vacancy notice) is "The following persons…", establishing disability as a defining factor, while "…are not allowed to apply" is the rheme, the new information which further reinforces the stereotype that impairment defines one's social worth in the society.

Discussion

Multimodal texts serve as powerful tools for challenging dominant ableist ideologies, redefining identities, and advocating for the rights and inclusion of persons with disabilities (PWDs) in society. By combining linguistic and visual modes, such texts frame perceptions, disrupt negative connotations, and promote fairness across social

hierarchies. The findings of this study reveal three key ways in which DRAC's Instagram narratives construct and represent PWDs, challenge power dynamics, and confront societal stereotypes, aligning closely with existing literature in the fields of English, literature, and Disability Studies.

First, the representations of PWDs on Instagram create awareness of discrimination and stigmatization while affirming their agency and social value. For example, the composite text in Figure 1 challenges erroneous labelling by emphasizing that "the most appropriate label is usually the one people's parents have given them." This approach aligns with the argument of Colin Barnes and Mike Mercer, who note that naming and representation play a crucial role in social inclusion, as labels can either reinforce or dismantle societal prejudice (529). By foregrounding self-determined identity, the narrative counters stereotypes and promotes recognition of PWDs as active participants in social life, rather than passive recipients of charity or pity, echoing existing works on disability as a site of social meaning-making and agency in literature.

Second, language emerges as a key instrument in perpetuating stereotypes and stigma. In Figure 2, the statement "...She will never understand anything" exemplifies verbal degradation that diminishes the individual's worth, echoing Tom Shakespeare's assertion that ableist language not only reflects but also reproduces social hierarchies and exclusion (45). Such language can breed low self-esteem, fear, and internalized oppression, confirming findings from critical discourse analyses in disability scholarship, which demonstrate that textual representations can enforce structural inequality (Norman Fairclough 95). DRAC's narratives disrupt these linguistic patterns by reframing disability as a societal, rather than individual, problem, highlighting how social attitudes rather than impairment create marginalization.

Third, the rejection of imposed euphemistic labels, as seen in Figure 3 ("I am not disabled or differently-disabled... I am an accountant in a wheelchair"), illustrates how DRAC uses multimodal strategies to reframe disability from a deficit-based identity to one emphasizing capability and professional identity. This aligns with Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's argument that cultural representations of disability can reshape public perception by emphasizing competence over limitation (1). The use of visuals alongside textual assertion reinforces this reframing, demonstrating the potential of multimodal discourse to contest cultural practices of "sugar-coating" disability, a phenomenon frequently documented in African socio-cultural contexts (Ogbu 20).

Finally, Figures 4 and 5 explicitly expose the consequences of stereotypes and social exclusion, using multimodal resources to educate the public and reconstruct the social image of PWDs. This finding resonates with studies in critical disability discourse (Shakespeare 46) that emphasizes the transformative role of representation in contesting marginalization. By strategically combining images, captions, and other semiotic resources, DRAC's posts not only advocate for the rights of PWDs but also actively challenge societal ideologies, demonstrating the effectiveness of multimodal approaches in advocacy, a key concern in English and literary analyses of social justice narratives.

Labelling in the Nigerian socio-cultural milieu is strongly tied to stereotypes and stigma. The findings show that multimodal resources assert personhood, reject reductive labels, and amplify narratives of inclusion, which parallels scholarship in English and Literary studies on the representation of marginalized identities (Afolayan & Akanmode 58). By

positioning disability as a reflection of societal attitudes rather than individual limitation, DRAC's narratives enact what Halliday terms ideational metafunction: representing social reality in a way that challenges hegemonic power structures. Similarly, the visual grammar reinforces interpersonal and compositional metafunctions, guiding audience interpretation and encouraging empathy, aligning with Kress and van Leeuwen's assertion that visuals can be used strategically to challenge power relations.

In sum, the findings suggest that DRAC's Instagram advocacy constructs PWDs as capable, socially visible, and agentive, challenges entrenched ableist ideologies, and uses multimodal strategies to contest stereotypes, condemn stigma, and promote social inclusion. These findings align with and extend existing literature in English, literature, and disability studies, demonstrating how multimodal discourse can be a site for both literary representation and social activism.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the multimodal resources in figures 1-5 above function as tools of empowerment and re-orientation that PWDs are not invalids in the society. Instagram with its multimodal affordances such as images, written texts, captions, hashtags, layout, topography, saturation, etc., has been a viable platform for challenging social issues like disability in the society. Each of the multimodal resources analysed conveys distinct messages-enlightenment, advocacy, reconstruction of identity, and social equity. Together, they construct narratives that challenge imposed labels, reject pity, affirm rights and dignity, and ultimately challenging negative perceptions of disability for a social change in the society.

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